Hills District had been created as early as 1866 and gradually expanded to include more areas in the easternmost mountains. In 1912, the Naga Hills District was formally incorporated into the new province of Assam. The Lushai Hills, now Mizoram, were ‘pacified’—colonial parlance for occupied—in the latter half of the nineteenth century and became part of British India in 1895. Today’s Meghalaya consists of the Khasi, Jaintia, and Garo Hills, highlands south of the Brahmaputra Valley. Its present state capital Shillong served as headquarters for the entire province of Assam because the colonial administrators preferred to stay in the cool climate in the hills, rather than in the hot and humid tropical plains of the Brahmaputra. Shillong remained the capital of Assam from independence in 1947 until 1972, when Meghalaya became a separate state.

To the north of the plain around the Brahmaputra, there were other hill districts, not as firmly controlled as the Naga, Lushai, Khasi, Jaintia, and Garo, but nevertheless considered part of Assam and British India. Following several British military raids into the hills north of the Brahmaputra in the late nineteenth and early twentieth century, in 1912, Major General Hamilton Bower, the leader of one of those expeditions, recommended that those frontier areas should be divided into three tribal-dominated sections—western, central, and eastern. That led in 1914 to the formation of the North-East Frontier Tracts under the government of Assam.[1] Five years later, the central and eastern sections became the Sadiya Frontier Tract, and the western section was renamed the Balipara Frontier Tract.

While Assam and its outlying hill areas were being consolidated, administrative changes were taking place in other parts of British India as well. In 1911, King George V had visited India and he conveyed his impressions in a speech before the British Parliament on 12 February 1912. India was the jewel in the crown of the British Empire and, at the same time as the 1912 Government of India Act was passed, it was decided to move the capital from Calcutta (now Kolkata) in the east to a more central location at Delhi.

The foundation stone of a new city, called New Delhi, had actually been laid during King George V’s visit, and the task of designing it was assigned to two prominent British architects, Edward Lutyens and Herbert Baker. However, because of the outbreak of World War I in 1914, the construction